

THE DONKEY WHO SPOKE

—*Numbers 22:22-35*

The sun had barely risen when Balaam set out on his journey to Moab. The morning air was cool, the earth damp with dew, and his faithful donkey stood ready, burdened with supplies for the long road ahead. Two servants followed close behind as Balaam joined the princes of Moab, their bright garments glinting under the early light. To any onlooker, it was a scene of purpose and promise. Yet heaven saw something far different.

Though the LORD had permitted Balaam to go, His anger burned against him. Permission, yes—but not approval. Balaam’s heart was still clinging to the promise of wealth and honor, hoping against hope that somehow, perhaps, the word of God might change. So, as the caravan moved forward, the LORD sent an angel to stand in Balaam’s path, sword drawn, ready to strike.

The donkey was the first to see him. Her large brown eyes widened at the sight of the gleaming sword and the radiant being who blocked the way. Startled, she bolted into a nearby field, ignoring her master’s commands. Balaam, blinded by pride and greed, saw only disobedience. With furious shouts, he struck her to drive her back onto the path.

They continued onward, the road now narrowing between vineyard walls. The angel appeared again—this time closer, the light of his presence filling the narrow way. The terrified donkey pressed against the wall to avoid him, crushing Balaam’s foot. Pain shot through him, fueling his anger. Again, he struck her, his face red with rage, his heart deaf to any whisper of warning.

Still, the angel moved ahead, waiting where the path grew so narrow there was no room to turn. The donkey froze. Trembling, she sank to her knees beneath Balaam’s weight. This final act enraged him beyond control. He beat her again and again until suddenly—something miraculous happened.

The donkey spoke. *What have I done to you,*” she asked, her voice gentle yet sorrowful, *“that you have struck me these three times?”*

Balaam, lost in his fury, didn’t even flinch. *“You have made a fool of me!”* he shouted back. *“If I had a sword, I’d kill you right now!”*

It was a moment that would have shaken any sane man, but Balaam’s pride and temper had blinded him more than any physical veil could. The donkey continued, her voice calm and reasoning, *“Am I not your donkey, the one you have ridden all your life to this very day? Have I ever done anything like this before?”*

Balaam’s anger faltered. His answer came slowly, almost ashamedly—*“No.”*

Then, in that instant, the LORD opened Balaam’s eyes. The world around him seemed to fall silent. Before him stood a mighty angel, radiant and terrible, sword drawn and ready. The light of heaven

reflected off the blade as the angel's voice thundered, *"Why have you struck your donkey these three times? Behold, I came out as your adversary because your way is contrary to Me. If she had not turned aside, I would have killed you and let her live."*

Balaam trembled, his arrogance shattered. He bowed low to the ground, confessing, *"I have sinned. If it displeases You, I will turn back."* But the angel's gaze softened only slightly. *"Go with the men,"* he said, *"but speak only what I tell you."*

The morning light seemed different now—still bright, but sobering. Balaam rose slowly, glancing at his donkey, the faithful creature who had just saved his life. Her sides still quivered from fear, but her eyes held a quiet innocence. Balaam's own heart, once puffed up with greed and pride, was pierced with the sting of humiliation and awe.

As the company resumed its journey, Balaam rode in silence. Each step of the donkey's hooves echoed the words of the angel in his mind. He now knew that he was not dealing with idols of stone or gods who could be bribed, but with the living God, who saw straight through the heart.

And somewhere between shame and reverence, perhaps Balaam realized the divine humor in it all. The prophet who sought to speak for gain had been rebuked by his own donkey—and she had shown more faith and obedience than he.

Indeed, the LORD has His ways. Sometimes, He reveals our folly with pain, other times with laughter. But always, if we humble ourselves, His mercy shines through.